was quite flimsy, yet we hung our maps and charts praying that the structure did not collapse on our heads! The war was initiated by Redland (exercise enemy) as it usually happens in our war games. During the first 24 hours, not much happened in our sector. The army commander went around all the Division HQs and other important Brigade HQs and was briefed by the commanders. He asked me a few questions and I responded as best as I could, but with confidence. After the briefing finished, quite a few people came over and congratulated me as nothing had gone awry. As I was quite new to my job and not so familiar with the area, it was some achievement.

The next day all hell was let loose in my division sector. It became clear that our defensive plans were going to be tested. The umpires kept on building the picture by giving us the progress of war. They also gave us the rulings on success or failure of our actions. At a critical juncture, the information given to us demanded immediate action on our part. I tried to get in touch with my corps commander, Lieutenant General H.B. Kala. He was moving around with the army commander and was thus unreachable. In the event, I ordered two companies to move from a flank that appeared less threatened, to beef up the defences of the area that was under heavy attack. This step caught the Redland off guard and their attacks got stalled. When the army commander asked me as to why I readjusted my defences on the first day itself, I replied that I acted before the enemy could create a critical situation for me. 'AKG', as he was known, then bowled a googly at me and said, 'What if the enemy does something on the side from where you have thinned out?' I did not lose my cool and replied, 'Sir, based on the information provided to us this was the best course of action in my reckoning. We will handle the situation in the other sector too by readjustments as rehearsed. Further, the enemy can't be everywhere.' AKG then asked, 'So you are not going to recall those companies?' I stood my ground and said 'No, Sir.' I believe I passed the test, as most of the other GOCs did not rise up the ladder subsequently. I was highly appreciative of General Kala, who held my hand because he was convinced that I had taken the correct